



Mid-Program Review

The 360° of Program Management

Bosch

--Ajay Akumal

<27/4/2026>

Introduction

Participant Name: Ajay Akumal

Manager Name : Pramod N M

Role: Project Manager and ECUupjm

Department: MS/ECV21-PS

Responsibilities and Activities:

Monitoring and controlling SW deliveries and timelines,

Understand customer requirements and propose changes/modifications to roadmap for its development .

Re-prioritizing tasks, Stakeholder management/engagement, negotiation, leading Cross-functional topics.

Feedback /appreciations, conflict management and competency management.

Customer :External customer: Audi and Porsche (VW group)



Module-wise Learning Application



Modules		Been able to apply	Identified areas to apply	No Scope to apply
Leadership	Leader in me	✓		
	Resilient Leadership	✓		
	Uncertainty Management	✓		
	Strategic Thinking & Creativity	✓		
Professional	Leading Cross-functional teams	✓		
	Negotiation Skills/Conflict Management	✓		

Note : Use the tick symbol to mark your relevant responses

Module Wise Key learnings

Empathy: Mastering Upward Empathy

Top 3 Learning:

See the Bigger Picture:

- Consciously looking beyond your team's immediate priorities. Learn complex web of pressures, targets, and constraints your own leaders are navigating from *their* superiors and the market.

Shift from Employee to Strategic Partner:

- Grasp challenges to become a trusted ally.
- Allies provide solutions and earn more responsibility.

Become the 'Why' Translator for my Team:

- Explain 'why' for effective leadership.
- Narrative transforms resistance into team buy-in.

Personal Resilience Practices

Top 3 Learning Practices:

Cultivate Self-Awareness & Mindfulness:

- Understanding my own emotions, triggers, and responses to pressure is fundamental. This involves recognizing the physical and emotional signs of stress and knowing my limits.
- Practices like mindfulness and reflective journaling are essential tools for building this internal awareness.

Prioritize Proactive Self-Care:

- I treat my physical and mental well-being as crucial components of my leadership performance. This means prioritizing adequate sleep, a healthy diet, and regular physical activity.
- Consciously taking time for activities I enjoy is not an indulgence but a necessary practice for maintaining long-term balance and effectiveness.

Build a Strong Support Network:

- Resilient leaders don't go it alone. I have focused on building and nurturing a network of trusted colleagues, mentors, and friends who can offer support, perspective, and encouragement during difficult times

Module Wise Key learnings

Seeing Beyond the Immediate

Top 3 Learnings:

Connect the Dots Between Daily Work and the Big Picture:

- Ability to constantly link my team's day-to-day tasks to the broader goals of Organisation.
- I don't just ask "What are we doing?"; I started asking "**Why** are we doing this, and how does it help us win in the long run?"

Anticipate Future Trends and Consequences:

- I mindfully try to Anticipate future opportunities, risks, and shifts. Considering long-term consequences of today's decisions.

Make Deliberate Trade-offs:

- Strategy is as much about what I decide *not* to do as what I decide to do.
- As a strategic leader, I recognize that resources are finite and make conscious choices to focus them on initiatives with the greatest long-term impact, even if it means saying no to other good ideas.

Negotiation & Conflict Management

Top 3 Learnings:

Prepare and Know My BATNA (Best Alternative To a Negotiated Agreement):

- Before entering any negotiation, I must know my walk-away point.
- Knowing my BATNA gives me the confidence to negotiate for a good deal and the clarity to reject a bad one.

Separate the People from the Problem:

- In any conflict, it's easy for emotions and personalities to become entangled with the issue.
- I actively depersonalize the disagreement by framing the situation as "us vs. the problem," acknowledging that both parties are smart, capable people with valid concerns.

Generate Options for Mutual Gain (Expand the Pie):

- I help teams avoid getting trapped in a single, win-lose solution.
- By dedicating time to collaboratively brainstorm a wide range of options, we can shift the dynamic from a battle to a creative, win-win partnership.

Application of learnings in different situations

Situation 1

Situation:

- ▶ My Program Director mandated a new, detailed weekly report for tracking all overdue work items in our RQ1 quality system. The directive was met with immediate groans from my team, who perceived it as time-consuming micromanagement that wouldn't help their project work. My own initial reaction was to see it as an unnecessary administrative burden.

Action Taken and learnings applied:

- ▶ **Paused and Reframed (Upward Empathy):** I took a moment to consider the Director's perspective. I knew our department had recently received tough feedback from Quality Management. I realized this new report wasn't about micromanagement; it was a tool to drive a culture of accountability and demonstrate a commitment to quality by systematically addressing open items.
- ▶ **Initiated a Partnership with the Team:** I scheduled a meeting with my team. Instead of presenting the task as a burden, I aligned them with the Director's strategic goal. I explained *why* this was important for the department's reputation and started a conversation focused on partnership: "How can we meet this new quality expectation efficiently and effectively?" I made a point to publicly appreciate those who were already closing items on time.
- ▶ **Offered a Solution (Co-Creation):** Based on the team discussion, we co-created a solution. We developed a simple script that automatically scanned our project's RQ1 data and flagged all open items. We scheduled this script to run every Thursday, giving the team a full day to address any outstanding issues before the end-of-week deadline.

Outcome

Before	After	Remarks
2 escalation meetings in 2025	0 escalations from 2026 feb Team protected from burnout.	The proactive approach of weekly RQ1 prevented monthly
Reactive culture and processes.	Proactive and collaborative culture.	A script became a valued weekly tool, shifting the mindset.
Average quality metrics and Open RQ1a.	0 issue with quality metrics of open RQ1s until Q1 2026	This demonstrated the direct impact of the new process.
Siloed operations within the team.	Sharing open items with other teams.	Solidified a reputation as a helpful and collaborative group.

Situation 2 :

Example:

- ▶ I had just been passed over for a promotion I had worked incredibly hard for. Despite my manager's positive framing of my future and current performance, I felt a deep sense of disappointment and my immediate instinct was to question my own value and replay every past mistake.

Action Taken:

- ▶ **Built on My Support Network:** Instead of isolating myself, I immediately scheduled a private call with a trusted mentor to honestly express my feelings and gain an objective perspective on my career path.
- ▶ **Practiced Self-Care (Boundaries & Physical Activity):** I gave myself permission to be "off" for an evening, setting a firm boundary by not checking work email to create a mental buffer. The next morning, I engaged in a strenuous workout, which was critical for processing the frustration and replacing the feeling of helplessness with a sense of accomplishment.
- ▶ **Cultivated Self-Awareness (Reframing):** I used my journal to reframe the situation. I wrote a list of my most significant accomplishments from the past year—the very achievements that made me a strong candidate. This powerful act of reflection re-grounded my sense of self-worth and reminded me of my capabilities.

Outcome:

- These deliberate actions prevented me from spiraling into prolonged demotivation.
- The conversation with my leader provided clarity, helping me see this setback as a single data point, not a final judgment.
- By consciously processing the negative emotions and reaffirming my value, I was able to return to work the next day with a constructive and professional attitude, ready to partner with my manager on a new growth plan.
- Bringing out optimism and motivation as a leader in self is also part of success

Situation 3

Situation:

- ▶ I lead a Customer Engineering team that, on the surface, was successful, consistently meeting its satisfaction goals. However, the team was completely reactive and drowning in a high volume of recurring tasks and deliveries (over 200 in the last year). They were burning out, and I discussed with my leader that simply hiring more people was not a sustainable solution.

Action Taken:

- ▶ **Looked Up and Out:** I shifted my focus from the immediate problem ("How do we complete deliveries faster?") to our department's strategic goals. I knew a key objective was to improve our Partner Experience Index (PEI) by 100%. I hypothesized that our reactive, high-volume workload—driven by rework and simple fixes—was a major barrier to achieving that strategic efficiency goal.
- ▶ **Analyzed for Root Causes:** I tasked a team member with a formal Lessons Learned (LLL) analysis, categorizing every incoming delivery for a week. The data was clear: over 30% of our work was caused by unresolved technical debt, documentation gaps, and basic competency issues. This data was the critical turning point, moving us from opinion to fact.
- ▶ **Made a Strategic Trade-off:** Armed with this data, we are proposing a new approach to our counterparts. We made a deliberate trade-off, shifting some of our team's focus from immediate delivery speed to long-term quality improvement. We invested time in enhancing integration awareness, started daily meetings to track and close technical debt (using our SOPL tracker), and drove the adoption of productivity improvement tools.

Outcome:

- ▶ The results are promising We are seeing a 30% drop in our open quality issues (SOPL points) in last 3 months.
- ▶ This strategic shift freed my team from constant reactive firefighting, allowing them to focus on more complex, high-value customer problems.
- ▶ We have a +ve feedback/Appreciation from Porsche on the Software Quality in April 2025 for the Latest EU7 software
- ▶ Our PEI score is now on track to improve significantly, and we've changed our engagement model, implementing "SMART" proactive measures from LLs also before committing to new deliveries.
- ▶ We are transforming from a reactive service team into a strategic partner that improves quality for the entire department.

Situation 4:

Application

Conflict Situation:

- ▶ A conflict arose when a PM for a new Porsche (PAG) project, under intense pressure to start, prematurely allocated resources from a critical Audi project.
- ▶ The Audi Subproject Manager (SPM) resisted, insisting that losing two people would guarantee a missed deadline, even though I could see his team's utilization could be improved.

Strategy Used:

Creating the psychological safety

I intervened by calling a meeting with both managers, not to assign blame, but to solve a shared departmental problem.

1.De-escalated and Separated People/Problem: I immediately framed the issue as a collaborative challenge.

I started by saying, *"I know both of you are completely committed to success. This isn't Audi vs. Porsche; this is us solving a complex puzzle... You both have valid goals, so let's tackle this resource problem together."*

2.Uncovered Underlying Interests: I asked probing questions to move beyond their stated positions. The SPM's true interest wasn't just "more people," but a *guarantee* that he could meet his delivery promise to Audi.

The PM's interest wasn't just to take people, but to establish a *predictable team structure* to show immediate progress on his high-priority project.

3.Pivoted to Objective Criteria: I shifted the focus from opinion to data. I instructed the SPM to prepare a detailed utilization plan for his existing team.

This plan became the objective, neutral ground for our discussion, changing the question from "Can I have two people?" to "How do we cover this specific list of tasks?"

Outcome:

- The data-driven approach worked perfectly. Thereby efficiently utilizing 100% of our resource allocation capacity .Without adding any new resources
- The teams collaboratively designed a slow, phased ramp-down of the two resources, giving the Porsche manager his predictable start while identifying internal efficiencies to protect the Audi timeline.
- The conflict was resolved because the solution was based on facts and data, not demands. Replanning efficiently.
- Both managers were satisfied as their core interests were met, and we reinforced a culture where we solve problems with data, not emotion.

Action Plan (Next 30–60 Days)

3 specific actions you will take:

1. Successful completion and usage of training and the material
2. AI tools usage in all the daily tasks as a supportive and guidance tool
3. Reflection on the experiential learning from each session bringing in visibility to self and team (creating branding)

How will you measure success?

Being able to connect these learnings with existing project and department to bring in benefits

Bring in the usage statistics towards end of the training session and quantify it with data similar to the current situation examples described earlier

The background features a dark, textured surface with numerous diagonal lines running from the top-left towards the bottom-right. These lines are composed of small, glowing orange and yellow particles, giving the impression of a digital or scientific visualization. The overall effect is a sense of depth and movement.

Thank You